SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #36 · CHURCH CULTURE AND EXPECTATIONS

“Good Christians never struggle.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Testimonies that jump from “then” to “now,” cheerful greetings, and unspoken rules about “fine” teach us that struggle is a mark against faith. People hide anxiety, doubt, marriage trouble, and sin, so everyone appears to be doing well alone.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture is full of struggling believers. Paul writes, “For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God,” and “My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.” He adds, “when I am weak, then I am strong.” Elijah prayed that he might die, and God sent an angel to say, “Get up and eat.” The psalmist says, “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted.” Struggle is not the opposite of faith. It is often where faith is exercised and grace is found.

> *“But He said to me, ‘My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.’ Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me. That is why, for the sake of Christ, I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in hardships, in persecutions, in difficulties. For when I am weak, then I am strong”* (2 Corinthians 12:9–10).

Also see

> “For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God” (Romans 3:23).

> “While he himself traveled on a day’s journey into the wilderness. He sat down under a broom tree and prayed that he might die. ‘I have had enough, LORD,’ he said. ‘Take my life, for I am no better than my fathers.’ Then he lay down under the broom tree and fell asleep. Suddenly an angel touched him and said, ‘Get up and eat.’” (1 Kings 19:4–5).

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

> “For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses, but we have one who was tempted in every way that we are, yet was without sin” (Hebrews 4:15).

Common self-statements

- Everyone else at church has it together.
- If I struggle, my faith is weak.
- I must say I am fine.
- Real Christians do not feel this way.
- I would be judged if they knew.
- I am the only one.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either strong in faith or failing.
- Mind reading: Assuming others would judge my struggles.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling ashamed and concluding that I am a bad Christian.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that I would be rejected if I were honest.

Challenging questions

- Where did I learn that Christians should not struggle?
- Which people in Scripture struggled, and how did God treat them?
- What do I think when I see someone else struggling?
- What does it cost me to say “fine” every week?
- Who might be safe to be honest with?
- What does God say to the weary?

Truth summary

> Struggle does not disqualify me. God’s grace meets me in weakness, and I can be honest with safe people. Honesty makes the church stronger.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Weakness
- Hardship
- Church
- Confession
- Suffering

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Divorce

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God’s care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
God’s companionship remains through darkness, weakness, and uncertainty.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Good Christians never struggle"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Good Christians never struggle." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Where did I learn this?
- ☐ Who struggled in Scripture?
- ☐ What do I think of others who struggle?
- ☐ What does "fine" cost me?
- ☐ Who is safe?
- ☐ What does God say to the weary?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God's grace is sufficient for me.
- ☐ Weakness is where Christ's power rests.
- ☐ Many in Scripture struggled.
- ☐ The Lord is near to the brokenhearted.
- ☐ Jesus sympathizes with my weakness.
- ☐ I can be honest with a safe person.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **2 Corinthians 12:9–10**
  "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me. That is why, for the sake of Christ, I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in hardships, in persecutions, in difficulties. For when I am weak, then I am strong."
- ☐ **Psalm 34:18**
  "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."
- ☐ **Hebrews 4:15**
  "For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses, but we have one who was tempted in every way that we are, yet was without sin."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Honest, not hidden: Each week, note one time you were honest about a struggle.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 2 Corinthians 12:9–10 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God's grace is sufficient for me in my weakness.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Weakness" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] List biblical strugglers. Write five and what God did.
- [ ] Pick a safe person. Choose someone who shares honestly.
- [ ] Share one struggle. Say it plainly.
- [ ] Memorize 2 Corinthians 12:9. Say it when you feel you must hide.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Good Christians never struggle": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Honest, not hidden
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Good Christians never struggle.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have hidden my struggles to look strong. Thank You for meeting me in weakness. Give me courage to be honest with safe people. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #37 · CHURCH CULTURE AND EXPECTATIONS

“I must look perfect to be accepted at church.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Dressing up, saying the right things, and keeping family problems private can turn church into a stage. Newcomers and those with messy lives sense that they do not match and either perform or leave.

What Scripture teaches

Jesus said to the religious leaders, “You are like whitewashed tombs, which look beautiful on the outside, but on the inside are full of dead men’s bones.” God told Samuel, “Man sees the outward appearance, but the LORD sees the heart.” Jesus answered, “It is not the healthy who need a doctor, but the sick.” Paul wrote, “If we say we have no sin, we deceive ourselves, and the truth is not in us.” The church is a gathering of forgiven people, not a showcase of finished ones.

> *“Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, you hypocrites! You are like whitewashed tombs, which look beautiful on the outside, but on the inside are full of dead men’s bones and every kind of impurity. In the same way, on the outside you appear to be righteous, but on the inside you are full of hypocrisy and wickedness”* (Matthew 23:27–28).

Also see

> “But the LORD said to Samuel, ‘Do not consider his appearance or height, for I have rejected him; the LORD does not see as man does. For man sees the outward appearance, but the LORD sees the heart.’” (1 Samuel 16:7).

> “Jesus answered, ‘It is not the healthy who need a doctor, but the sick.’” (Luke 5:31).

> “If we say we have no sin, we deceive ourselves, and the truth is not in us. If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness” (1 John 1:8–9).

> “And let us consider how to spur one another on to love and good deeds. Let us not neglect meeting together, as some have made a habit, but let us encourage one another, and all the more as you see the Day approaching” (Hebrews 10:24–25).

Common self-statements

- I have to look put together.
- They would not want me if they knew.
- I have to hide my mess.
- Everyone else is polished.
- I do not fit in.
- I must perform.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either perfect or unacceptable.
- Mind reading: Assuming people are judging my appearance and life.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling out of place and concluding I do not belong.
- Fortune telling: Predicting rejection if I show my mess.

Challenging questions

- What does “perfect” look like at my church, and who decided?
- Who in my church is real about their struggles?
- What did Jesus say about people who looked perfect but were not?
- What would change if everyone dropped the act?
- What does God see when He looks at me?
- What small step toward honesty could I take?

Truth summary

> God accepts me as I am, and the church is meant to be a community of the forgiven. I do not need to be polished. I can be real with those who are safe, and help make church a safe place.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Church
- Hypocritical
- Pride
- Grace
- Confession

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

Is He Worthy — Andrew Peterson
Honest recognition of a broken world can lead to hope in Christ’s final restoration.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus’ love rather than personal strength.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I must look perfect to be accepted at church"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I must look perfect to be accepted at church." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What does perfect look like here?
- ☐ Who is real?
- ☐ What did Jesus say?
- ☐ What if the act dropped?
- ☐ What does God see?
- ☐ What step can I take?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God sees my heart.
- ☐ Jesus came for the sick, not the healthy.
- ☐ The church is for sinners saved by grace.
- ☐ I do not have to perform.
- ☐ Honesty invites honesty.
- ☐ I can encourage others.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 1 Samuel 16:7
  "But the LORD said to Samuel, 'Do not consider his appearance or height, for I have rejected him; the LORD does not see as man does. For man sees the outward appearance, but the LORD sees the heart.'"
- ☐ Luke 5:31
  "Jesus answered, 'It is not the healthy who need a doctor, but the sick.'"
- ☐ 1 John 1:8–9
  "If we say we have no sin, we deceive ourselves, and the truth is not in us. If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Real at church: Each week, note one honest moment at church.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Luke 5:31 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Jesus came for the sick, so I do not have to look perfect.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Hypocritical" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Notice the act. Write what you do to appear perfect.
- ☐ Be real once. Share a true answer to "How are you?"
- ☐ Welcome a newcomer. Greet someone who looks out of place.
- ☐ Read Luke 5:31. Remember who Jesus came for.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I must look perfect to be accepted at church": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Real at church
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must look perfect to be accepted at church.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I am tired of performing. Thank You for accepting me as I am. Help me be real, and help our church be a place where people can be honest. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #38 · CHURCH CULTURE AND EXPECTATIONS

“If I doubt, I'm a bad Christian.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Many were taught that questions are sinful and faith means never wondering. Seasons of loss, unanswered prayer, or hard questions then bring fear and shame. People hide doubts and feel alone.

What Scripture teaches

A father cried out to Jesus, “I do believe; help my unbelief!” and Jesus healed his son. Jude writes, “have mercy on those who doubt.” The Bereans “examined the Scriptures every day to see if these teachings were true,” and Luke calls them noble-minded. Hebrews says, “faith is the assurance of what we hope for and the certainty of what we do not see.” Doubt can be a doorway to deeper faith when we bring it to God and to Scripture instead of hiding it.

> *“Immediately the boy’s father cried out, ‘I do believe; help my unbelief!’”* (Mark 9:24).

Also see

> “And indeed, have mercy on those who doubt” (Jude 1:22).

> “Now the Bereans were more noble-minded than the Thessalonians, for they received the message with great eagerness and examined the Scriptures every day to see if these teachings were true” (Acts 17:11).

> “Now faith is the assurance of what we hope for and the certainty of what we do not see” (Hebrews 11:1).

> “Why are you downcast, O my soul? Why the unease within me? Put your hope in God, for I will yet praise Him for the salvation of His presence” (Psalm 42:5).

Common self-statements

- Real believers never doubt.
- My questions prove I do not believe.
- God is angry at my doubts.
- I cannot tell anyone.
- I am losing my faith.
- I should not ask.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I either have perfect faith or none.
- Mind reading: Assuming others would condemn my questions.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling uncertain and concluding that my faith is gone.
- Fortune telling: Predicting I will lose my faith.

Challenging questions

- What am I doubting, specifically?
- How did Jesus respond to the father who admitted unbelief?
- Who in Scripture asked hard questions of God?
- What could I do to look for answers instead of hiding?

- Who could I talk with who welcomes honest questions?
- What do I still hold on to?

Truth summary

> Honest doubt brought to God is not a failure of faith. Jesus welcomes “I believe; help my unbelief.” I can ask questions, seek answers, and keep trusting.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Faith
- Doubt
- Trust
- God, All Loving
- Wisdom

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Divorce
- Forgive/Forgiveness

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God’s care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

Truth Be Told — Matthew West featuring Carly Pearce
Honesty about struggles makes room for grace and support instead of pretending to be fine.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If I doubt, I'm a bad Christian"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I doubt, I'm a bad Christian." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What do I doubt?
- ☐ How did Jesus respond?
- ☐ Who asked hard questions?
- ☐ Where can I look?
- ☐ Whom can I ask?
- ☐ What do I still hold?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Jesus welcomes honest doubt.
- ☐ God has mercy on those who doubt.
- ☐ Examining Scripture is noble.
- ☐ Faith can grow through questions.
- ☐ I can bring my questions to God.
- ☐ I am not alone in doubt.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Mark 9:24
  "Immediately the boy's father cried out, 'I do believe; help my unbelief!'"
- ☐ Jude 1:22
  "And indeed, have mercy on those who doubt."
- ☐ Acts 17:11
  "Now the Bereans were more noble-minded than the Thessalonians, for they received the message with great eagerness and examined the Scriptures every day to see if these teachings were true."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Questions brought to God: Each week, write one question and where you looked for an answer.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Mark 9:24 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I believe; help my unbelief.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Faith" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Name the doubt. Write it in one sentence.
- [ ] Pray Mark 9:24. Say it honestly.
- [ ] Study. Look up the question in Scripture or with a trusted pastor.
- [ ] Talk to someone. Share it with a wise believer.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I doubt, I'm a bad Christian": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Questions brought to God
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I doubt, I'm a bad Christian.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I believe; help my unbelief. Thank You for welcoming my questions. Lead me to answers and keep me close to You. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #39 · CHURCH CULTURE AND EXPECTATIONS

“My church's rules are the same as God's love.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Where rules about dress, music, entertainment, or conduct are taught as the heart of faith, breaking one can feel like losing God’s favor. We confuse a community’s customs with God’s character and cannot tell where the church ends and God begins.

What Scripture teaches

Jesus said, “You have disregarded the commandment of God to keep the tradition of men.” Paul writes, “It is for freedom that Christ has set us free. Stand firm, then, and do not be encumbered once more by a yoke of slavery.” He also warns against human rules, “Do not handle, do not taste, do not touch!” which “are of no value against the indulgence of the flesh.” And “neither death nor life… nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord.” God’s love is not earned by keeping a church’s rules. Real obedience flows from that love.

> *“It is for freedom that Christ has set us free. Stand firm, then, and do not be encumbered once more by a yoke of slavery”* (Galatians 5:1).

Also see

> “You have disregarded the commandment of God to keep the tradition of men” (Mark 7:8).

> “If you have died with Christ to the spiritual forces of the world, why, as though you still belonged to the world, do you submit to its regulations: ‘Do not handle, do not taste, do not touch!’? These will all perish with use, because they are based on human commands and teachings. Such restrictions indeed have an appearance of wisdom, with their self-prescribed worship, their false humility, and their harsh treatment of the body; but they are of no value against the indulgence of the flesh” (Colossians 2:20–23).

> “For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord” (Romans 8:38–39).

> “Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest. Take My yoke upon you and learn from Me; for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls. For My yoke is easy and My burden is light” (Matthew 11:28–30).

Common self-statements

- If I break a rule, God is angry.
- The rules are what God wants.
- I am only loved if I conform.
- If they disapprove, God does too.
- I am safe when I follow every rule.
- I cannot question.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either obedient to all rules or rejected.
- Mind reading: Assuming the church speaks for God in everything.

- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty and concluding that God is displeased.
- Fortune telling: Predicting punishment for any deviation.

Challenging questions

- Which rules are in Scripture, and which are customs?
- What does Scripture say is the heart of God's will?
- How do I feel when I break a church rule?
- Does God's love depend on my keeping those rules?
- Who in my church lives in freedom and love?
- What would help me sort out the difference?

Truth summary

> God's love is not the same as my church's rules. I can honor godly leaders and clear Scripture while recognizing human customs. Nothing can separate me from the love of God in Christ.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Grace
- Church
- Obedience
- God, All Loving
- Guilt/Shame

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Love
- Divorce

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

If We Are the Body — Casting Crowns
The church is called to welcome and care for people rather than exclude or shame them.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This familiar hymn places confidence in Jesus' love rather than personal strength.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "My church's rules are the same as God's love"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My church's rules are the same as God's love." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Which rules are Scripture?
- ☐ What is the heart of God's will?
- ☐ How do I feel when I break a rule?
- ☐ Does God's love depend on them?
- ☐ Who lives in freedom?
- ☐ What helps me sort it out?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Christ has set me free.
- ☐ Human traditions are not God's commands.
- ☐ Nothing can separate me from God's love.
- ☐ Christ's yoke is easy.
- ☐ I can honor leaders and test teaching.
- ☐ I obey out of love, not fear.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Galatians 5:1**
  "It is for freedom that Christ has set us free. Stand firm, then, and do not be encumbered once more by a yoke of slavery."
- ☐ **Romans 8:38–39**
  "For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord."
- ☐ **Matthew 11:28–30**
  "Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest. Take My yoke upon you and learn from Me; for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls. For My yoke is easy and My burden is light."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Love, not fear: Each week, note one act of obedience out of love, not fear.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Galatians 5:1 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Christ has set me free, and nothing can separate me from His love.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Grace" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Sort the rules. Write which are Scripture and which are custom.
- [ ] Study Galatians 5. Read and underline freedom.
- [ ] Talk with a mature believer. Ask for help sorting.
- [ ] Pray Romans 8:38–39. Thank God His love holds.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "My church's rules are the same as God's love": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Love, not fear
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My church's rules are the same as God's love.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You love me apart from rules. Help me tell Your commands from human customs, obey out of love, and rest in Your grace. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #40 · CHURCH CULTURE AND EXPECTATIONS

“If I leave my church, I'm leaving God.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Some churches teach, openly or quietly, that they are the only true place to meet God. After conflict, hurt, a move, or changing convictions, members stay out of fear. Others leave and feel they have walked away from God.

What Scripture teaches

Jesus said, “surely I am with you always, even to the end of the age,” and “where two or three gather together in My name, there am I with them.” Paul writes that the church is one body with many parts, and “He is before all things, and in Him all things hold together.” Hebrews urges, “Let us not neglect meeting together,” so fellowship matters, but no single congregation owns God. When a church is harmful or no longer fits, a prayerful, honest, and gracious departure is not leaving Him.

> *“And let us consider how to spur one another on to love and good deeds. Let us not neglect meeting together, as some have made a habit, but let us encourage one another, and all the more as you see the Day approaching”* (Hebrews 10:24–25).

Also see

> “The body is a unit, though it is composed of many parts. And although its parts are many, they all form one body. So it is with Christ” (1 Corinthians 12:12).

> “He is before all things, and in Him all things hold together” (Colossians 1:17).

> “For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord” (Romans 8:38–39).

> “Plans fail for lack of counsel, but with many advisers they succeed” (Proverbs 15:22).

Common self-statements

- This church is my only connection to God.
- If I leave, I will lose Him.
- Leaving is betrayal.
- They will say I fell away.
- I cannot find God anywhere else.
- I must stay no matter what.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either in this church or away from God.
- Mind reading: Assuming leaders will see me as rebellious.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty about leaving and concluding I am leaving God.
- Fortune telling: Predicting spiritual disaster.

Challenging questions

- Why am I considering leaving, and is it sin, hurt, or conviction?
- Has anyone in this church harmed me?
- What does Scripture say about meeting with believers?
- Who could I counsel with, inside and outside this church?
- What kind of fellowship would help me grow?
- How can I leave, if I do, in peace and honesty?

Truth summary

> God is not confined to one congregation. Fellowship with other believers is important, and I can seek wise counsel, leave gracefully if needed, and find a healthy home. Nothing can separate me from His love.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Church
- Guidance
- Will of God
- Wisdom
- Friendship

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Divorce
- Love

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

Truth Be Told — Matthew West featuring Carly Pearce
Honesty about struggles makes room for grace and support instead of pretending to be fine.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If I leave my church, I'm leaving God"

✦ ✦ ✦

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Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I leave my church, I'm leaving God." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Why consider leaving?
- ☐ Has anyone harmed me?
- ☐ What does Scripture say?
- ☐ Whom can I ask?
- ☐ What fellowship helps?
- ☐ How can I leave in peace?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God is with me wherever I go.
- ☐ The church is one body with many parts.
- ☐ Fellowship matters.
- ☐ Wise counsel guides decisions.
- ☐ Leaving gracefully is possible.
- ☐ Nothing separates me from God's love.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Hebrews 10:24–25

  "And let us consider how to spur one another on to love and good deeds. Let us not neglect meeting together, as some have made a habit, but let us encourage one another, and all the more as you see the Day approaching."

- ☐ 1 Corinthians 12:12

  "The body is a unit, though it is composed of many parts. And although its parts are many, they all form one body. So it is with Christ."

- ☐ Romans 8:38–39

  "For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

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PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Seeking wisely: Each week, note one prayer or conversation about your church decision.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Hebrews 10:24–25 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God is with me always, and I can seek wise counsel about church.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
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6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Write your reasons. List why you are considering leaving.
- [ ] Seek counsel. Talk to a trusted mature believer outside the situation.
- [ ] Pray and study. Read Hebrews 10:24–25 and 1 Corinthians 12.
- [ ] Stay connected to God. Keep Scripture, prayer, and fellowship going.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I leave my church, I'm leaving God": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

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My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I leave my church, I'm leaving God.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I fear that leaving would mean leaving You. Thank You for being with me always. Give me wisdom, wise counselors, and a healthy place to grow. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.